

Claude Code Session Handoff Process

A simple guide to managing context limits and continuing work across sessions.

One-Time Setup Per Project

On the first session of any new project folder, ask Claude to create the memory file:

```
"Create a CLAUDE.md file in the project root to track session summaries
and project context."
```

This only needs to be done once. The file stays in the folder permanently.

During the Session - Watch the Status Bar

Monitor the context usage shown in the Claude Code status bar:

- **80-85% context** - Trigger your end-of-session summary now
- **100% context** - Too late; compaction may have already dropped context

End of Session Prompt (at 80-85%)

Run this before ending your session:

```
"Update CLAUDE.md with a detailed session summary.
Include: what we worked on, all files modified or created,
current status of each task, decisions made, known issues,
and exact next steps. Add a timestamp."
```

Start of New Session (Same Folder)

Run these prompts in order:

1.

```
"Read CLAUDE.md and tell me where we left off."
```

2.

```
"List the current files and folders in this directory."
```

3.

```
"Based on that, let's continue with [next task]."
```

The Cycle

```
New project -> create CLAUDE.md once
|
Work -> hit 80-85% context
|
Ask Claude to update CLAUDE.md
|
End session -> open new session same folder
|
Claude reads CLAUDE.md -> fresh 200k window
|
Continue working -> repeat
```

Key Reminders

- CLAUDE.md is per project folder - one file, stays there permanently
- Update it before hitting 100% while Claude still has full context
- New session = fresh 200k window with CLAUDE.md as the memory bridge
- CLAUDE.md does not consume your 200k context - it's read once at startup
- Run `cat CLAUDE.md` in terminal anytime to check its contents
- For cross-project preferences, use `~/ .claude/CLAUDE.md` (global config)